



Joy Mohun Bagan!

Despite the loss in the final, where Mumbai City avenged its defeat in the final league match, Mohun Bagan reigned supreme as the **bearer of the League Shield.**

Everyone has to appreciate that the Shield winner winning the league title qualifies as the greatest achievement in Indian football. Mohun Bagan Super Giant realised it in the 10th edition of the Indian Super League, where it could not find ultimate success. Mohun Bagan displayed impressive consistency throughout the league stage, ultimately overcoming the formidable Mumbai City FC to win its first 'Shield.' The final league match was effectively a knockout final, and Mohun Bagan emerged victorious, defeating Mumbai City FC 2-1 and earning the highest number of points (48 points) ever achieved by a team in the tournament's history.

Mumbai City, needing a draw to win the shield, faltered at the last post and was consigned to the list of the vanquished despite netting 47 points to emerge as the second-best. Mohun Bagan's achievement meant that the opponents in the succeeding playoff stage had to acknowledge its feat with a 'guard of honour'. The Odisha FC team had to give a standing ovation to Mohun Bagan players as they came out of the tunnel to play the first leg of semifinal 1 at the Kalinga Stadium. Mohun Bagan lost the match 1-2, but its accomplishment remained undiminished.

The Mariners won the second leg 2-0 to reach the final, where they were outdone by Mumbai City FC 3-1. Despite the loss in the final, where Mumbai City avenged its defeat in

the final league match, Mohun Bagan reigned supreme as the bearer of the League Shield. The joy of winning the Cup was diminished as Mumbai City FC had to acknowledge Mohun Bagan's shield triumph as a greater accomplishment. It had to accord a guard of honour to Mohun Bagan as its players went to the podium to receive their medals. Mumbai City, which won an ISL double in the 2020-21 season by beating the same opponent, could very well appreciate the sense of triumph and satisfaction that was then prevailing in the Mohun Bagan camp.

Amitabha Das Sharma

Taming the Gaurs

After packing his bag, the diary frantically travelled to the airport to board a morning flight from Chennai to Goa. The ever-lingering fear of missing a flight can be hard to shrug off, no matter how frequent a flyer one is. The reason for the trip from the Bay of Bengal to the Arabian Sea? — Football.

The second Indian Super League (ISL) 2023-24 seminal pitted FC Goa against Mumbai City FC — a delicious fixture, not just for the quality of football but also for the amalgamation of fans belonging to two states so different in their cultures, despite being separated by just 600 kilometres.

On April 24, the day of the semifinal, as the diary was making preparatory notes about the upcoming clash, chants of 'Forca Goa' and 'Feel the Uzzo in the air' prompted him to go to the hotel



balcony, from where he had a clear view of the sprawling green inside the Fatorda Stadium, the venue for the semifinal first leg.

Cut to the match, FC Goa did not disappoint the full-capacity crowd, dishing out some excellent football, which led to the Gaurs relishing a 2-0 lead till the 89th minute.

Seven minutes later, the Mexican waves from the orange-clad fans had stopped. The flashlights were off. And except for the West Coast Brigade (MCFC fan club) chanting their hearts out, the entire stadium